

Impact: High Difficulty: Medium Misuse risk: Medium

## CORE FORMULA

Cut words in half -> Lead with the point -> Earn elaboration

## MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Take whatever you were about to say and cut it in half. Lead with the most important word or sentence. Leave the rest.

## BEST FOR

- Written communication — email, messages, reports
- Presentations with time constraints
- High-stakes verbal answers where clarity matters most
- Any communication where the reader or listener is busy

## PHRASE BANK

### Brevity Openers · Signalling you are being concise

- "Short version: ..."
- "In one sentence: ..."
- "The headline is..."
- "Two things: ..."
- "I will keep this brief: ..."
- "The core of it is..."
- "Bottom line: ..."

### Cut Phrases · Catching and shortening

- "Actually — let me say that more simply."
- "I am over-explaining. The point is: ..."
- "Shorter version: ..."
- "Let me get to the point faster."
- "I will spare the context and say: ..."

## WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Three paragraphs of context before the ask  
Better: Here is the background — I need X.  
**Best: I need X by Y. Context in one sentence below.**
2. Weak: Five-minute verbal explanation of a simple point  
Better: I will try to keep this short...  
**Best: One sentence answer. Pause. Add one piece of context only if needed.**
3. Weak: Email with no clear structure: all text, no hierarchy  
Better: I have organised this into sections.  
**Best: Key point in bold at the top. Brief support below. Clear ask at the end.**

## DECISION TREE

### If You are about to write a long email

Ask: can I say this in one paragraph? One sentence? Cut accordingly.

### **If You are about to give a long verbal answer**

State the core in one sentence first. Offer detail after.

*"The short answer is X. Happy to give you more context if useful."*

### **If You are mid-sentence and realising it is too long**

Stop. Restate in fewer words.

*"Actually — let me cut that down. The point is simply: ..."*

### **If You are being brief but losing important information**

Add back only the essential context. Not everything that is interesting.

*"The one piece of context that changes this is..."*

## **SCENARIOS**

### **Replying to a senior person's question in a meeting**

One sentence answer. Then pause. — "Yes — the project is on track for Thursday."

### **Writing a message to someone with limited time**

Lead with the ask. One line of context. Stop. — "I need your sign-off on X. Background below if useful."

### **Explaining a complex idea to a non-expert**

Say the clearest version. Cut the jargon. — "The simplest way to say it is..."

### **Giving a status update in a meeting**

Status first. Risk second. Ask third. Everything else is noise. — "On track. One risk: [name it]. No decisions needed from you right now."

## **WHEN NOT TO USE**

- In relationship-building contexts where brevity reads as cold or dismissive.
- When explaining complex technical topics to non-experts — completeness matters more than brevity.
- In emotional conversations where being concise can feel uncaring.

## **7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL**

### **Day 1 — Word count audit**

Take one email you wrote today and cut it by half. Notice what you removed. Was it necessary?

### **Day 2 — One sentence test**

For every question you are asked today, attempt a one-sentence answer before elaborating.

### **Day 3 — Lead with the point**

In three communications today, put the most important sentence first.

### **Day 4 — Earn the detail**

After a brief answer, wait to be asked for more before adding it.

### **Day 5 — Cut filler**

Identify and remove all filler phrases from one communication: 'as I mentioned', 'just to say', 'I wanted to reach out' etc.

### **Day 6 — Verbal brevity**

In one meeting, aim to make your contributions 50% shorter than usual.

### **Day 7 — Calibration**

Was your communication received better? Did brevity ever cost you something important? Where was it most effective?

## **AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST**

- Did I cut the communication by at least a third?
- Did I lead with the most important point?
- Did I offer elaboration rather than force it?
- Did I remove all filler phrases?
- Was the brevity appropriate for the context — not cold in a warm situation?
- Did I write in a way that respects the reader's time?
- Did the communication land more clearly as a result?